Executive Summary: Care System Load 2023-2025

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Care load across CBP custody and HHS care peaked at 11,762 children around the turn of 2023 to 2024 and has since fallen to 2,502, so pressure is far lower than at its peak.

Where pressure built. Three prolonged strain windows appear in the daily data (7-day average load in the top 25% of the period). The main one ran from 7 Aug 2023 to 22 Jan 2024 (169 calendar days), followed by 25 Jan to 27 Mar 2024 (63 calendar days), so the system was under sustained strain for about 7.5 months. A shorter window ran from 1 to 23 May 2023. No prolonged strain has appeared since March 2024.

Where the system stands. Over the full period discharges exceeded transfers into HHS by 44.7 children per day on average, and discharges were 1.35 times transfers. Day-to-day swings in total load are only about 2% of the average, and the 7-day backlog rate is slightly negative (-1.3), so no backlog is building.

Outlook. The 30-day forecast shows load staying almost flat at about 2,495 to 2,499 children, close to today’s 2,502. It is a statistical estimate, not an official capacity limit.

Recommendations

1. Treat the 7-day average load and the sustained-pressure flag as early warnings, and plan staffing and shelter space when the 7-day average enters its top quartile.
2. Add bed and shelter capacity to the data, so utilisation can be measured instead of inferred.
3. Review days where transfers exceed recorded custody counts, to confirm reporting definitions are consistent.

Limits of this analysis. The data records counts of children, not available beds, so it shows pressure and trends but cannot prove overcrowding. About a third of calendar days (355 of 1,075) have no report, which limits how precisely short-term pressure can be measured.